

Safety First

When I was a kid the first thing I remember being taught was “Safety First”. Each time I went outside to play with friends, I was reminded by my parents to be safe. Now I am grown up, and I have a daughter of my own, I understand my parents' concerns, and I worry constantly about my daughter's safety and wellbeing. For each and every one of us, safety is such an important concept, and we build our lives around it. We build houses to stay safe from the outside, we work hard to secure our future so that we can support our households, have food at our table, and live good lives with our family. We also build community for the purpose of staying safe. Governments are formed and people within government are tasked with the job of protecting public wellbeing and keeping society safe. Protecting the common good by creating health infrastructure and oversight is one of the most important roles that a government must undertake.

Even in the most advanced society all of us must still be concerned about our safety. This was seen in action very recently during the COVID-19 pandemic; when I heard people mention the FDA and CDC more often than I have ever in my lifetime. Many were looking up to these organizations to end the pandemic and make us feel safe again as a society. People were all ears for guidelines and directions for public health safety provided by CDC by all means of communications. When the time came for the FDA and CDC agreed upon authorize the first mRNA vaccine against the SARS-CoV2 virus and encouraged everyone to receive the vaccine to promote their safety and that of others. CDC roll was very challenging at that point as people started to worry about the safety of the vaccine and its effectiveness and argued that government agencies didn't have the right to tell them what to do. Even some of my own family members protested against these rules and began to mistrust the judgment of the CDC for implementing FDA authorized new therapeutics without having enough reviewed data. One can argue about CDC and WHO to intervein and do further research for the treatment safety and efficacy before implementing anything coming from FDA.

During this time, I was working towards completing my prerequisite studies that would enable me to matriculate into pharmacy school. I became curious about the process of drug development and how new therapeutics are approved to come to market. Later, in pharmacy school, I learned about therapeutic agents and their mechanism of action, as well as some of the rules and fundamentals of the approval process for a drug. I am still craving for mor information how CDC makes decisions and creates guidelines for any approved drug and how they review and monitor new data to make changes in their recommended guidelines. I think my APPE experience with CDC Division of Heart Disease and Stroke Prevention with Dr. Nicole Therrien PharmD, MPH will be able to provide the knowledge and understand how the ART team conducts public health and policy research and build tools to support implementation of evidence-based practices and policies for public safety. As the ART team also translates complex research into digestible information to be used by public health professionals, pharmacists, and policy makers I will be able to gain very important skills for my future career plan which is to go into drug development research; and as recently I was accepted into the conjoint Master's in Pharmaceutical Science program, which will help me learn more about the research process and provide a foundation for my planned future career. Thus, I was excited to learn about the opportunity to conduct an elective with CDC as an APPE student. In particular, I am interested in learning how drug safety and efficacy is reviewed with the goal of protecting and promoting public health. I believe that this experience will be highly beneficial for my development as a biomedical researcher where I hope to contribute to the development of therapeutic agents for the betterment of public health, but always with the fundamental rule of “Safety First” in mind.